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6,000 held for visa violations post amnesty

ARRESTS WERE MADE DURING 270 INSPECTION CAMPAIGNS, REVEALS ICP

DUBAI

BY AGHADDIR ALI
Senior Reporter

The Federal Authority for Identity, Citizenship, Customs and Ports Security (ICP) in the UAE has arrested 6,000 individuals who have violated visa rules in the UAE after the amnesty ended on December 31 last year.

Addressing a press conference in Abu Dhabi yesterday, Major General Suhail Saeed Al Khaili, Director-General of ICP, said the arrests were made during 270 inspection campaigns that were conducted. "These inspection campaigns reflect our unwavering dedication to enforcing the country's legal framework," Major General Al Khaili said.

"We will continue to intensify our efforts to ensure that all individuals residing in and visiting the UAE adhere to the established legal standards," he added.

Enhancing security

He said 93 per cent of those arrested had their deportation procedures completed. These inspections followed the conclusion of a four-month grace period for violators to adjust their status. The grace period, which ran from September 1 to December 31, 2024, gave individuals an opportunity to either leave the country voluntarily or regularise

93%

of those arrested had finished deportation procedures

their status by obtaining a new work contract. This initiative was part of the ICP's broader strategy to encourage compliance and enhance the nation's security.

ICP made it clear that no leniency would be shown toward violators, as the rule of law would be fully enforced. The law enforcement operations also address the social, economic and security challenges that arise from violations of foreign entry and residency regulations.

The inspection campaigns were carried out in coordination with relevant government authorities. They were strategically planned to target locations with the highest concentration of violators. Legal actions were swiftly taken, with fines imposed on both violators and individuals or organisations found guilty of harbouring or employing them illegally. The Foreign Entry and Residency Law has also granted the authority some new powers and has defined the penalties for any violations committed by violators.

SEE ALSO P3



Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

SKILLS AND THRILLS AT UAE SWAT CHALLENGE

Swat teams show their skills at UAE SWAT Challenge 2025 in Dubai. Organised by the UAE Ministry of Interior and hosted by the Dubai Police General HQs, the event has drawn a record-breaking 105 teams from 46 countries.



Watch: Elite SWAT teams in action at UAE SWAT challenge

UAE unveils Dh200b logistics strategy

Cabinet reviews train project, launches UAE Government Innovation Month

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

His Highness Shaikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, yesterday chaired a Cabinet meeting at Qasr Al Watan in Abu Dhabi.

On his X account, Shaikh Mohammad stated: "Today, I chaired a Cabinet meeting,

where we reviewed one of the most significant national infrastructure projects — the Etihad Rail Passenger Train — which was recently launched. The train operates at a speed of 350km/h and is expected to contribute over Dh145 billion to the GDP over the next five decades."

Global trade hub

The Cabinet approved the establishment of the Emirates Council for Logistics Integration, aimed at unifying efforts and ensuring seamless coordination and integrational roles to strengthen the UAE's position as a global trade hub. The council will bring together all key

players in the logistics sector at both federal and local levels, including ports, roads, transportation, customs and railways, among others.

"In 2023, the logistics sector was valued at approximately Dh129 billion. Our goal is to increase this figure to over Dh200 billion within the next seven years," the Vice-President said.

The Cabinet launched the UAE Government Innovation Month, reinforcing innovation as an integral part of the government's culture, operations and implementation mechanisms. The cabinet also approved the National Cybersecurity Strategy.

SEE ALSO P4

Indian expats to get unified passport centre

ABU DHABI

BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

All passport and attestation centres for Indian expats in the UAE are set to change, as the Indian missions plan to launch a unified service centre with branches in 14 locations no sooner than the second quarter of this year, *Gulf News* can reveal.

The Indian Embassy in Abu Dhabi has reopened a tender inviting bids from service providers to run Indian Consular Application Centre (ICAC) which will merge all the consular services under one facility.

The Embassy has proposed 14 branches of ICAC to serve more than four million Indians living in the UAE and foreigners seeking Indian visa services through the Indian missions here.

Currently, two different service providers offer outsourced services for the missions. BLS International processes the passport and visa applications while IVS Global handles the document attestation services and some services are handled at the Embassy and the Indian Consulate in Dubai.

Quick and transparent

The new unified facility is proposed to offer comprehensive, quick and transparent services in prime locations with strict requirements to streamline services, reduce waiting times and ensure enhanced efficiency and accessibility.

Dubai-based Lebanese girl emerges as world's top AS Psychology student

Michelle Sayegh says it's a very emotional moment

DUBAI

BY SHARMILA DHAL
UAE Editor

A Dubai-based student has done herself and the UAE proud by emerging as the top performing AS Psychology student in the world.

Michelle Sayegh, a Lebanese student of Year 13 at GEMS Wellington Academy — Silicon Oasis, told *Gulf News*, "This is a very emotional moment for me and I want my teachers to share the credit with me as their support meant a lot. Essentially, this is the first stage of A Level Psychology under the Oxford AQA board."

Christine Arnott, Head of Psychology at WSO, said, "Michelle was initially crowned the



Michelle Sayegh

She said, "Although it is the most significant achievement at this juncture for her, Michelle is a very modest young lady."

Changing lanes

The modesty is more than apparent when Michelle confessed that although she was always fascinated by the human mind, psychology was her second career choice. "I wanted to pursue medicine but couldn't quite make the cut in the UK colleges I wanted. The rejection deeply hurt but when one of them offered me Psychology, I took it as a sign that that was the line for me. So I changed my plans for the future."

Michelle said she is looking forward to going to university next year.

"I would like to explore the various branches of psychology over the four years in university, before zeroing in on what I will specialise in," she added.

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